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Assembly - Democrat to run for vacated office - Immigrant attorney Jesse Gabriel files for Dababneh's Valley seat

January 4, 2018 | Los Angeles Daily News (CA)
Author: Kevin Modesti | Section: News | 397 Words
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Jesse Gabriel, a Democratic attorney who has been fighting the Trump administration on behalf of young immigrants, has entered the race for Matt Dababneh's old California Assembly seat representing the West San Fernando Valley.

Gabriel, 36, an Encino resident, made the announcement Wednesday and asserted his prominence in the District 45 race by saying he has raised more than $300,000 in two weeks and is endorsed by state Sen. Ben Allen, D-Santa Monica.

Gabriel is the fourth candidate to file a statement of intention to run. Others are Democrats Samantha Stevens and Ankur Patel and Republican Justin Clark.

A date has yet to be set by Gov. Jerry Brown for a special election to replace Dababneh, who resigned effective Dec. 31 after women accused him of sexual misconduct. Earlier, Raul Bocanegra resigned his Assembly seat in the northeast Valley following accusations of sexual harassment.

"I think we need to resist the bad public policy coming out of Washington, D.C., that's going to be bad for Californians and really goes against our values," Gabriel said in a phone interview. "And we

need to think about things that are important to our community," including environment, education, infrastructure and quality-of-life issues.

"Sacramento has enormous power to help address some of these issues. If the Trump administration is going to pull out of the Paris climate accords, then we as Californians can sign our own accords," Gabriel said.

Gabriel, who grew up in the Ventura County community of Oak Park, moved to Encino from Santa Monica in July with his wife, Rachel Rosner, also an attorney. They have 2-year-old and 3-month-old sons.

Gabriel, a constitutional-rights and general-litigation attorney with Gibson, Dunn & Crutcher, said he has spent most of the past 10 months working on lawsuits seeking to protect undocumented young people known as Dreamers from Trump administration efforts to roll back Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) protections.

A Harvard law graduate, he was counsel to Sen. Evan Bayh, D-Indiana. Gabriel serves on the the Los Angeles County Commission on Local Government Services, and on the boards of the L.A. League of Conservation Voters and the Jewish Federation of Greater L.A.

Democrats enjoy a more than 2-1 edge over Republicans in voter registration in District 45. Dababneh's and Bocanegra's resignations, along with Sebastian Ridley-Thomas' resignation last week for health reasons, has at least temporarily dropped Democrats below a two-thirds supermajority in the Assembly.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**

Modesti, K. (2018, January 4). Assembly Democrat to run for vacated office - Immigrant attorney Jesse Gabriel files for Dababneh's Valley seat. *Daily News of Los Angeles (CA)*, p. 3. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1693829C037BD498.